

The Stories of the Mountain

(18th November, 2025)

"I can't do this anymore!" I stopped. I sat down on the side of the mountain and gave up.

I've always loved walking through nature. There's something calming about towering trees, mountains disappearing into the clouds, and standing in freezing streams under a sky full of stars. So, when the UTS Hiking Club announced an overnight hike to Acacia Flat in the Blue Mountains, my friend and I didn't think twice.

As we began the trail, everyone was laughing, singing, and making up songs to remember the weekend. The hike leader smiled and joked, "I like how optimistic you all are. I hope you stay the same by the time this hike is over." The hike hadn't even officially begun when the group decided to make things "a little more interesting." Instead of heading straight towards the campground, we took a detour around the Grand Canyon Track, a casual three-hour addition.

Three hours later, after climbing over rocks, stepping through puddles, squeezing between bushes, the official trail was only just beginning. As the group started to descend into the valley, so did my will to live. The first few hours felt manageable. We laughed, took photos, and convinced ourselves we were making great progress. By the fifth hour, we had taken countless breaks, emptied more water bottles than I could count, and the campground was still nowhere in sight.

Someone called out from behind us. "Girls, your pace is slow. At this rate, we'll take another hour." I was petrified. I picked up my pace. Looking back, I don't think they were discouraging us, they were simply stating facts. But my mind had to make up its own story. The sun began to set and we hiked in the dark. Armed with a phone flashlight instead of a headlamp, shoes whose soles had long given up, and a wooden stick proudly pretending to be a hiking pole. The boys kept encouraging us. "Just twenty more minutes." After hearing it for hours, those words stopped sounding like encouragement and started sounding like false hope.

Nine hours after we had started, we finally reached the campground. That relief lasted less than a minute. There was no network and the last message I had sent my mum read, "I'll message you when I reach the campground." I was worried that I have stressed my family. This deeply made me realise the things I have taken for granted and what I still have to be grateful for.

The next morning, we woke up with a little more hope than energy. This time, the goal wasn't just to finish the hike. We wanted to reach somewhere with a network and let our families know we were okay. For a while, that was enough to keep us moving. The painkillers I had taken the night before slowly wore off and I was in pain. Somewhere between trying to catch my breath and convincing myself to keep walking, our group split into two. My friend ended up in the group ahead. I stayed behind. "Did we lose the track?" "What if she isn't okay?" "What if we don't end up back together?" By the time we reunited, I didn't even say anything. I just hugged her.

Strange, how I had always believed resilience meant doing hard things on your own. Somewhere on that mountain, I realised that resilience is allowing others to carry part of your weight until you remember how to carry yourself again.

Five hours into the hike, somewhere in the middle of the mountains with barely enough space for one person to stand, I stopped. I sat down. I looked at the group and quietly said, "You guys go ahead. I'm done." For the first time in my life, I genuinely believed I had reached my limit. I looked up at the clouds and whispered the only thing I could think of. "Please... just let this end. I can't do this anymore." My friends stayed with me without saying much, just being there in silence. In that moment I realised it wasn't my body that had given up, but my mind that had convinced me I couldn't go on.

Moments later I got up. Eventually, we reached Victoria Falls. My friend grabbed my hand and together we yelled, "Carpe Diem!" For the first time that weekend, I wasn't thinking about how much further we had to go. I was simply grateful to have made it that far.

The hike leader smiled and pointed towards the final stretch. "Just another 600 metres." After everything we had already climbed, six hundred metres somehow sounded both comforting and terrifying. The final climb was nothing but an endless staircase. My body still hurts. My legs were still screaming at me to stop. The mountain hadn't suddenly become easier. But something else had changed.

The stories in my head had. Instead of asking, "*Can I make it?*" I found myself asking, "*What's the next step?*" Somewhere between those two questions, everything changed. The long hike ended and we finally reached. Our reward, a dreamy view of the milky way. It was divine.

Ironically, nothing about me had changed physically. I wasn't fitter. I wasn't stronger. Yet somehow, I walked away feeling different. Looking back, I don't think the biggest lesson from that hike was resilience. It was learning that giving up isn't always the end of the story. We spend so much of our lives believing the stories our minds create. "*I'm not enough, I'm slowing everyone down, I can't do this.*" Sometimes those stories prepare us, but sometimes they're simply wrong. The mountain never told me to stop; my mind did. I gave up. I sat down, convinced I had nothing left to give. Yet, because of the kindness of those who stayed beside me and the quiet decision to take one more step, I stood up again. For that, I'll always be grateful. That hike reminded me that strength isn't about never reaching your breaking point. It's about finding the courage to get back up, even when you've already convinced yourself you can't.